

Rabbi Marshal Klaven

Researcher and Author: *"Full Exposure: The Revealing Picture of Jewish Engagement with Tattooing"*

A pivotal shift has occurred in the public's perception of tattoos. No longer are tattoos the sole proprietary earmarks of sideshow carnival actors, rough sailors, greasy bikers, or hardcore gang members. Today, tattoos are the adornment of suburban moms, coming-of-age markers for college students, personal testimonials of professionals' wild days long past and even life-long memorials to loved ones. In fact, a 2007 Pew Research Center survey showed that 36% of 18-25 year-olds have at least one tattoo, while an even higher percentage (40%) of 26-40 year-olds have at least one as well. ("How Young People View Their Lives, Futures, and Politics." 09 January 2007)

The growing appeal of the tattoo is not lost on Jews. Yet, the provocative question – "to be or not to be tattooed" – should arouse the modern Jew (who wishes to remain both modern and Jewish) to expose more than just the skin. It should provoke them to reveal the historical picture of the Jewish engagement with the tattooing. Captured therein will be a complex view comprised of shades of gray, as our ancestors were both tattooers and tattooees from antiquity to modernity, identifying appropriate uses for the tattoo (e.g. solidifying one's relationship to the people of Israel or the God of Israel) and inappropriate uses for the tattooing (e.g. idolatry or punishment).

Rather than the black and white presentation tattoos have often been given by many Jewish leaders up to this point, this more focused perspective may be more accurate and helpful to the modern Jew when navigating this crossroad of modernity and tradition!